ONE-OFF SHIURIM

# Why Judge Others Favourably?

Derech Hashem 2:6:1-3

**Sefer:** Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 6, paragraphs 1-3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 15 July 2021

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## Review: the system of hashgahah

Part 2 has covered over what Hashem exercises hashgahah, its rules, and its manner, ending last week with miracles. Chapter 6 describes the system. Paragraph 1, reviewed again, says Hashem arranged the running of His world to mirror the way things work on earth: "the kingdom of heaven reflects the kingdom of earth," with courts at different levels, prosecutors and defenders, before which every matter comes and through which every decree is carried out. It is not just Hashem judging alone; there is a whole system around Him, and the reason, as said last time, is to teach us how we should do things.

## Paragraph 2: Hashem's presence in the courts

Hashem's presence is felt in all these courts, and in some of them He actually sits at the head. The prophet says: "I saw Hashem sitting on His throne, and all the host of heaven standing on His right and on His left." There is no right and left in heaven. The right are those who advocate for a person's merit; the left are those who argue against him. Daniel saw thrones set up, the Ancient of Days sitting, and books opened.

Are there thrones and books in heaven? No. It is "as if": Hashem made the system as if there were a throne, a court, books, and people for and against. This is the language of Rosh Hashanah, with the books open, the prosecutor (kategor), the defender, and the Satan.

So in some courts Hashem is not actively judging, but His presence ensures it runs properly; in others He is the head, and the angels feel His presence directly. Like a company: for the big cases the CEO attends; for others he reads the reports and makes sure everything is running properly.

A participant asked whether that implies the court could get it wrong and Hashem overrides it. The Rabbi said yes: that is why He is there, as the ultimate decider. Asked what happens if courts below are crooked, he explained that the symmetry is theoretical: in theory courts here should run by law and justice, and that ideal is reflected in heaven, where it always does.

A participant raised the Mishnah in Pirkei Avot: "Do not judge alone, for none judges alone except the One." Does that not say Hashem does judge alone? The answer: it refers to the final

seal. There is a whole system for reaching it, but the final approval is His alone.

## "Omnam": every act has many angles

The Ramhal continues (top of page 77) with what the Rabbi called a beautiful paragraph. Everything that happens to a person is precise and nothing happens by itself. Yet every human action can be seen from different perspectives, and judged differently depending on the angle. In every deed there is a good angle and a bad angle, and many more. All these aspects are brought out in the heavenly courts, where each member sees the matter through his own eyes: one through compassion, another through strict judgement. Through all of them everything is revealed and nothing is left out, and then it is gathered together and the decree comes out.

The Rabbi's example: a man makes a large donation in shul. One angel says, what a charitable person. Almost always there is also some element of ego, "that's just human nature," and another angel says he did it for his own honour, not for the honour of Heaven. The court weighs the whole and decides how to view the act.

## Dan lekaf zekhut

This explains the Gemara in Shabbat: one who judges his fellow favourably will himself be judged favourably. The commentators ask: a human cannot read minds, so if I see someone walk into a non-kosher shop, I can choose to assume he went to buy a drink. But in heaven they know exactly what you did. How can "judging favourably" apply there?

According to the Ramhal it fits beautifully. Even when every act is known, there are different ways to view it. Should we focus on the charity and the good heart, or on the bit of honour he wanted? Take a holistic positive view, or come down on the small flaws? If you have a good eye and see people positively, the heavenly court does the same for you: "Yes, we've dissected your action, there's a bit of good, a bit of bad, but we'll look at it and the whole is something good." A participant added that it works both ways: judge others harshly and you will be judged harshly.

## Three things that recall a person's sins

The same idea underlies the Gemara's three things that cause a person's sins to be recalled, putting a spotlight on him: - **Walking under a leaning wall**, putting himself in danger. - **Iyun tefillah:** praying hard and then expecting the prayer to be answered. - **Handing judgement over to Heaven:** in a dispute, saying "God will judge between us." Who are you? Heaven will start looking at you.

"Everything which you do, you can interpret it bad. Everything which you do, you can interpret it good as well. It's about your perspective in life." The more positively you see others, the more advocates in the court will search out the good in you.

## The final seal, and paragraph 3

The Ramhal adds that the final verdict is sealed only by the head of the court, in the courts where Hashem sits at the head. Even though He knows the outcome, He allows the process:

each side argues its case, and then the matter is concluded. And if the court's conclusion is not right, He will not stamp something He does not agree with.

"This is really the importance of seeing things in a positive eye in life... It's very hard for people to do things purely altruistically. You have to look for the good within them."

Paragraph 3 draws the key conclusion: Hashem judges not according to His knowledge alone, but according to the system He established. Nothing is judged until the angels appointed to oversee events bring it forward. Hashem never instigates a case on His own accord; it always comes through prosecutors or defenders bringing it before the court, even for the largest events in the world. This, the Ramhal says, has nothing to do with Hashem's knowledge, which needs none of it; He decreed it in His wisdom.

This helps explain the shofar's power "to confuse the Satan" on Rosh Hashanah. Hashem set up a system with a prosecutor; if you can reach the verdict without the prosecution being heard, you come out with a good judgement.

A participant asked about vast events such as the Holocaust. The Rabbi said that where human beings are involved there is another dimension, as discussed in the past ("where was God, where was man?"). For events like COVID or a tsunami, how they affect each person would come through such instigation, within the overall direction in which Hashem is leading the world. The chapter will be finished on Monday, the last class before the summer. Chapter 7, on astrology, and Chapter 8 remain before Part 3, on the soul and prophecy.

## Summary

- Hashem runs the world through heavenly courts at many levels, mirroring human courts; thrones and books are "as if."
- In some courts He sits at the head; in all, His is the final seal, and He can overturn a wrong conclusion.
- Every act has good and bad angles, and the court weighs them all; one who judges others favourably is judged favourably.
- Hashem does not judge by His knowledge alone, nor instigate cases; they are brought by the appointed agents.
- This is why on Rosh Hashanah we seek to "confuse the Satan," so that no prosecution is heard.

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